Bye-Bye Screens

5 scripts for the hard moments

From chapter 3 of Bye-Bye Screens. Keep it on your phone or stick it on the fridge.

1

When there's a meltdown when the screen goes off

Don't argue in the middle of a meltdown. No argument works on someone who's very upset.

1. Name what they're feeling: “You're really mad because you wanted to keep watching.”
2. Hold the limit without yelling: “It's still off. There's more tomorrow.”
3. Offer the next step: “Want to help me set the table, or should we go find the ball?”
4. Wait. Sometimes it takes a while. If you give the screen back to calm them down, they learn that meltdowns work.

Ready to say

“I get it, it's hard to stop something you like. It's done for today. Now you choose: should we draw or go outside?”

2

When they say “I'm bored”

Don't solve their boredom with a list of 20 options. Offer two, or send them to the boredom-buster box.

Ready to say

“Great, boredom is when you get your best ideas. Pick a card from the box or choose one of these two: ___ or ___.”

3

When they say “my friend's parents let him”

Ready to say

“Maybe. Every family has different rules. In our house, this is the rule, and we chose it because we want you to sleep well and play a ton.”

4

When they bargain for “just five more minutes”

If you already gave the heads-up, there are no extra minutes. If you give in once, they'll bargain every time. If you want to be flexible, offer it before they ask.

Ready to say

“I already gave you a heads-up and the timer already rang. Not now. If you want, we can talk about it tomorrow before you start.”

5

When they say “you're mean” or “I hate you”

It hurts, but it's almost always the anger talking. Don't hit back with words of your own.

Ready to say

“You're really mad at me. I still love you. And the screen is still off.”

This is part of chapter 3

The full book has the 30-day plan with one task a day, 120 activities by age (2 to 12), step-by-step limits for phones, tablets, YouTube and the TV, and 3 printable bonuses.

Ask for it on WhatsApp: +54 9 11 3514-9209

Bye-Bye Screens is a practical guide for families. It does not replace advice from your pediatrician or other health professionals. If something worries you, ask one.